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MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM
MGU-UGP (HONOURS) Regular EXAMINATION October 2025
Third SEMESTER
Discipline Specific Elective (DSE) - MG3DSEHIS200 - THE ANCIENT SOCIAL FORMATIONS FROM HUNTER GATHERERS TO THE CLASSICAL ANTIQUITY
(2024 ADMISSION ONWARDS)

Duration: 2 Hours **Maximum Marks: 70**

Remember (K), Understand (U), Apply (A), Analyse (An), Evaluate (E), Create (C), Skill (S), Interest (I) and Appreciation (Ap)

SCHEME

Part A (MCQ)
Answer any **10** questions- Each question carries **1** marks

1. b). Charles Darwin
2. d). Savagery-Barbarism- Civilization
3. c). Cleisthenes
4. b). Polytheistic
5. a). Stone carving
6. c). A Religious, Administrative and Economic Centre
7. a). Rise of markets and trade
8. b). Justice and the Ideal state
9. a). Dugout canoes with paddles
10. b). Cuneiform
11. a). Hittite Empire
12. b). A thriving and stable agricultural system

Part B (SHORT ANSWER)
Answer any **5** questions- Each question carries **2** marks

13. The discovery of grinding stones at a Mesolithic site indicates that people were processing plant materials such as seeds and nuts, showing a diversification of their diet beyond hunting and fishing. This suggests an evolving subsistence strategy where Mesolithic communities increasingly utilized plant resources, reflecting their adaptation to postglacial environments and a gradual shift toward sedentary life-ways.

14. Labour force, Pyramid construction, Domestic service, Agricultural work, War captives, Debt bondage, Temple labourers, Social hierarchy, Economic production, State control.
15. Pastoral nomadism contributed to cultural exchange and the diffusion of ideas by facilitating interactions, trade, and the spread of technologies, languages, and beliefs across diverse regions through their constant mobility and wide-ranging networks.
16. The Roman mob played a crucial role in politics and society by influencing public opinion, pressuring leaders through demonstrations, and serving as a force that politicians sought to control through entertainment and grain distributions.
17. Fertility – Earth goddess – Terracotta figurines – Matriarchal belief – Agricultural prosperity – Female deity – Symbol of creation – Worship rituals – Household shrines – Continuity in later Hindu traditions.
18. Well-planned – Covered drains – Brick-lined channels – Street drainage – Household connections – Soak pits – Manholes – Regular maintenance – Advanced sanitation – Urban planning.
19. **Oiketes** – Greek household slave – Domestic servant – Attached to family – Performed household duties – Dependent on master – Integral part of ancient Greek household economy.

20. **Solidus** – A gold coin introduced by Emperor Constantine in the Roman Empire – High purity – Stable currency – Used for trade, taxation, and salaries – Replaced the aureus – Basis of Byzantine monetary system.

Part C (SHORT ESSAY)

Answer any **4** questions -Each question carries **5** marks

21. Kinship ties – Clan authority – Social cohesion – Resource sharing – Conflict resolution – Collective labour – Inheritance norms – Leadership roles – Ritual unity – Social organization.
22. Cultural interaction – Parallel development – Shared innovations – Local adaptation – Trade networks – Migration – Environmental factors – Multicentric evolution – Cross-cultural influence – Integrated explanation
23. Alexander deserved the title "The Great" for his extraordinary military conquests, unifying much of the known world and spreading Greek culture across vast regions. However, his legacy is debated, as his empire fragmented after his death and his ambition often brought destruction along with cultural fusion.
24. Emperor Augustus – Pax Romana – Political stability – Administrative reforms – Cultural revival – Golden Age of Latin literature – Imperial expansion – Artistic patronage – Roman law – Foundation of Empire.
25. Social cooperation was essential for successful hunting strategies, as coordinated group efforts allowed early humans to plan, track, and capture large or fast-moving animals more efficiently. It also fostered communication, role specialization, and food sharing, strengthening social bonds and ensuring group survival.
26. Environmental resource availability, particularly access to metals like copper and tin, directly shaped technological innovation in Bronze Age cultures by enabling advancements in toolmaking, warfare, and trade networks.
27. Sparta – Militaristic society – Professional soldiers – Rigorous training – Hoplite army – State discipline – Collective warfare. Athens – Citizen militia – Naval power – Triremes – Democratic leadership – Strategic warfare – Civic duty.

Part D (ESSAY QUESTION)

Answer any **2** questions- Each question carries **15** marks

28. The growth of the Roman agrarian economy was facilitated by fertile Mediterranean lands, advanced irrigation, slave labour, and the expansion of trade networks. Over time, large estates (latifundia) replaced small farms, creating economic inequality and rural depopulation. Its eventual decline resulted from overreliance on slave labour, soil exhaustion, heavy taxation, and political instability that disrupted agricultural productivity.
29. Reciprocity in Palaeolithic groups ensured that food and resources were shared among members, preventing accumulation and fostering cooperation. Tolerated theft allowed individuals to take small portions from others without conflict, discouraging hoarding. The immediate return system, where resources were consumed soon after acquisition, prevented inequality and maintained social balance within the group.
30. The rise of the Shang civilization can be traced to the Erlitou culture (c. 1900–1500 BCE)**,** which shows early state formation with bronze casting, palatial architecture, and social stratification. The Erligang phase (c. 1500–1300 BCE) marked the expansion of urban centers like Zhengzhou, advancement in bronze technology, and the establishment of a centralized political system. The Anyang phase (c. 1300–1046 BCE**)** represented the mature Shang state, with well-planned cities, royal tombs, oracle bone inscriptions, and a complex ritual system. Together, these phases reflect the gradual evolution from a regional chiefdom to a fully developed early Chinese civilization.
31. The Delian League, initially formed to defend Greek city-states against Persia, declined as Athens transformed it into an imperial instrument serving its own interests. The misuse of league funds, imposition of Athenian control, and suppression of member revolts bred resentment among allies. Continuous wars, especially the **Peloponnesian War**, exhausted resources and exposed the fragility of Athenian dominance. Ultimately, the defeat of Athens by Sparta in 404 BCE marked the League's collapse, revealing that imperial overreach and loss of mutual trust undermined its original purpose.